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In contemporary development discourse, transnational efforts to improve underdeveloped areas are often perceived as a form of neocolonialism. Through this view, the manifestation of international development as both a mode of thinking and a set of practices is seen as only possible through a rearrangement and reassertion of imperial and capitalist methodologies. Development actors and processes are institutionalized as Western displays of power and knowledge and act to restrict the sovereignty of many parts of the Global South. These groups undergoing development are therefore obliged to maneuver and assert their agency only within the structural limits imposed by the institutions.¹ In this paper, I will explore the concern of conservation management in the Global South as an expression of neocolonialism, and discuss how environmental colonialism has shifted forms and practices over the past centuries. To do so, I will use the example of South Asia, specifically focusing on the Mount Everest region of Nepal. Through employing a postcolonial framework to deconstruct the complex colonizing narratives at play here, I argue that environmental colonialism has undergone a process of evolution in the Everest region, manifesting as three temporally and spatially distinct yet interrelated configurations through militarization, governance, and indirect anthropogenic activities.

Environmental colonialism, also known as green imperialism, refers to the ways in which colonial practices have impacted their occupied natural environments. The term first appeared in

¹ Jiménez Peña, "Is Development a Form of Neo-Colonialism?"

1989 in relation to debt-for-nature swaps, a practice of international development that entails a portion of a nation in the Global South's foreign debt being forgiven in exchange for local investments in environmental conservation measures.² Critics of this program employ the term environmental colonialism in their argument that debt-for-nature swaps can lead to a new ecological colonial system in which imperial powers are able to maintain dominant influence in previously colonized areas. The theory of imperial powers as drivers of ecological change is closely related to the idea of the Anthropocene- a new geological epoch in which humans have emerged as the dominant biophysical force shaping global climate and environments.³ However, many academics have criticized the Anthropocene as dislocating blame for global environmental shifts from imperial powers and redistributing it to all of humanity- "by responsabilizing all of humanity for climate change, instead of the colonial processes that have actually driven it, Anthropocene discourses risk further masking and naturalizing this colonialism."⁴ Inseparable histories of settler colonialism are what underlie many environmental issues in the Global South, but an understanding of how these inequalities are produced and maintained is generally missing from conservation development initiatives' frameworks.⁵

Nepal's history is deeply entangled with the colonial legacies and politics of South Asia. Although the country has never been formally colonized by another country or religious group, Nepal has been a site of global interest for centuries due to its natural resources and strategic location in South Asia. The country's political-economic history has progressed similarly to a Marxist model- characterized by primitive communism, then a period of slavery, followed by a

² Bedarff, Holznagel, and Jakobeit, "Debt-For-Nature Swaps."

³ Crutzen and Stoermer, "The 'Anthropocene' (2000)."

⁴ Young, "Environmental Colonialism, Digital Indigeneity, and the Politicization of Resilience."

⁵ McCreary and Milligan, "The Limits of Liberal Recognition."

feudal period, a capitalist period, and, most recently, the incorporation of socialist ideas.⁶ Beginning in the 19th century, elements of a capitalist system began to manifest in Nepal through the geopolitical influence of the East India Company. Direct trade links were established between India and Tibet through Nepal, thus bringing the country into the global market. This capitalist restructuring of Nepal additionally facilitated the rise of ethnic politicization and anti-imperialist movements.⁷ The British Empire perceived any large Indigenous and fairly untouched state as a threat to their hegemony, and conflicts between Nepal and the British East India Company over control of land for agriculture and taxation, and access to lucrative trade routes between Tibet and India led to the eruption of the Anglo-Nepal War between 1814 and 1816.⁸

The resulting Sugauli Treaty of 1816 ceded almost half of Nepal's territories to the East India Company,⁹ signaling that systems of imperialism had begun to become more formally incorporated into the history, policies, economics, and relationships of Nepal. The Treaty also allowed the East India Company to sow the seeds of a capitalist transformation of Nepal's economy that would allow for the further encroachment of global imperial and corporate interests into Nepal. Internal colonization, displacement, and marginalization are also of note, as foreign powers were not the only groups perpetuating imperial systems. For example, in Nepal, Indian imperialist attitudes continue to manifest through activities such as trade blockades, disputes related to border and territory encroachments, flooding caused by dams on rivers in the border areas, unjust trade and transit treaties since the time of British India, and the micromanagement of Nepal's internal affairs by the Indian embassy.¹⁰ The Rana Dynasty, which

⁶ Prasad Katel, "Imperialism in Nepal: Past and Present."

⁷ Pinter, "Transformations of Political Consciousness in the Process of State Formation in Nepal."

⁸ Crews and Mukherjee, "What About Postcolonial Politics in Nepal?"

⁹ Kumari and Kushwaha, "Sugauli Treaty 1816."

¹⁰ Pouchepadass, "Colonialism and Environment in India."

stayed in control of Nepal for 104 years with the support of British India, provided Nepali soldiers (Gurkas) and material contributions to the British army during World Wars I and II. After democratic movements facilitated the fall of the Rana Dynasty in the 1950s, the United States became involved in the political affairs of Nepal as part of its efforts to supervise China. In reaction to the United States' involvement in Nepal, China has also begun to assert influence over Nepal, especially in the contested border zone areas.¹¹

The first form that I identified environmental colonialism to take manifested as the direct destruction of colonized land through both the militarization of conquest and campaigns to establish legitimacy, as well as the exploitation of natural resources for economic gain. This phase happened on a global scale, but faced extra difficulties in the harsh habitats of South Asia (Nepal itself avoided much of the military action of colonialism, but this form of environmental colonialism is seen in many of the surrounding areas). Although many groups in South Asia were far outmanned and outgunned by imperial conquerors, they were able to use their knowledge of local environments to their advantage to put up a good fight. For example, the kingdom of Kandy in modern-day Sri Lanka was well hidden in a mountainous region and protected with a thick forest cover, but the forests were demolished by the British military during their imperial conquest.¹² To invading forces, forests stood in the way of political hegemony- they were seen as obstacles to the movement of armies, they could easily become a base of resistance, and they provided a convenient refuge to criminals.¹³ Through violently clearing the physical

¹¹ One interesting thing that I observed during my fieldwork in the Khumbu region of Nepal that borders China was that China had provided vaccines against Covid-19 to residents of this region at a time that many people in the United States didn't even have access to receive one (early 2021). This appears to be strong evidence of how geo-political relationships directly affect development efforts, especially in areas that are highly contested and could pose a security risk.

¹² "The Kingdom of Kandy in Sri Lanka."

¹³ Pouchepadass, "Colonialism and Environment in India."

environmental obstacles that stood in the way of colonial conquest, imperial powers gained and asserted control, and engaged in an extreme form of boundary-making that would have detrimental effects on local ecological systems for centuries to come.

Further direct degradation of colonized environments was facilitated by the economic practices of imperial powers in their goal to extract as many natural resources from the land as possible. One example is found in New Zealand, where European settlers confiscated land from Māori tribes and took over most of the country so that they could extract as much timber as possible from the forests. Present-day New Zealand has at least 60% fewer forests than before European colonization, and dozens of endemic bird species have gone extinct.¹⁴ The militarization of natural resource extraction through armed violence has played a critical role in environmental degradation in many parts of the Global South. This concept, ecological unequal exchange theory, contends that nations that lie at the core of the world system hierarchy are able to take advantage of the human labor capital and natural resource wealth of periphery nations.¹⁵ By bringing new environmentally degrading activities and practices to colonized territories, imperial nations were able to further establish legacies of economic inequality and ecological destruction.

Besides using direct violence and economic constraints to force local populations to participate in natural resource extraction, other aspects of this militarization include armed conflict between state and non-state actors, violent repression carried out by state and rebel

¹⁴ “Deforestation and Colonization of Aotearoa/New Zealand – The Decolonial Atlas.”

¹⁵ Jorgenson and Clark, “The Economy, Military, and Ecologically Unequal Exchange Relationships in Comparative Perspective.”

forces, and the use of mercenaries to protect natural resource assets.¹⁶ Violent conquest not only physically forced local populations to engage in natural resource extraction, but it also facilitated the growth of an economic system in colonized areas that limited livelihood opportunities and created conditions of poverty. This forced colonized communities to continue to exploit the natural resources of their land in order to ensure their survival. For example, at the end of the 19th century, French colonizers in North and West Africa banned rural communities from practicing their centuries-old sustainable subsistence farming methods in an attempt to profit from their wage labor and integrate them into the global agriculture-export economy. The local populations were forced to chop down forests to make way for cotton plantations and other cash crops throughout French Equatorial Africa, which led to intense long-term environmental degradation.¹⁷

The second form of environmental colonialism that manifested in South Asia was in the form of governance of local populations. After the conquest period of land clearing as a militarized act of boundary making and imperial power assertion, the relationship between colonizer and colonized evolved further. Foreign administrative bodies that once subjected governed groups to harsh economic conditions that forced them to exploit their own land, now turn the blame for environmental degradation onto the marginalized populations themselves. The very same complex social arrangements that were instituted, organized, shaped, directed, and controlled by imperial institutions to exploit natural resources from colonized land were now appropriated for conservation management. Governance of Indigenous populations by foreign administrations, justified by the necessity of environmental conservation, brings in the concept of

¹⁶ Downey, Bonds, and Clark, "Natural Resource Extraction, Armed Violence, and Environmental Degradation."

¹⁷ "How Colonialism Spawned and Continues to Exacerbate the Climate Crisis."

traditional ecological knowledge, which was ignored and rejected during this time. In 2000, Berkes et al. defined traditional ecological knowledge as: “a cumulative body of knowledge, practice, and belief, evolving by adaptive processes and handed down through generations by cultural transmission, about the relationship of living beings (including humans) with one another and with their environment.”¹⁸ In recent years, traditional ecological knowledge structures have been commercialized and exoticized to the benefit of the same institutions that had ignored the value of this knowledge and Indigenous lives for centuries.¹⁹

The Sherpas in the Mount Everest region of Nepal are one example of a community recognizing the importance of conservation of their land, but ultimately failing to be recognized in official law. Sherpas’ significant contributions to conservation in Nepal’s national parks are undermined and threatened by inadequate recognition/respect for their Indigenous Community Controlled Areas²⁰ in official national legislation, lack of representation in national park management conversations, and through the policies and practices of the Nepalese Ministry of Culture, Tourism, and Civil Aviation. The MoCTCA manages the trekking and mountaineering industries in Nepal and is deeply involved in the decision-making and policy implementation processes that regulate the environmental impact of expedition teams,²¹ but the Nepalese government offers little recognition, involvement, and/or protection of those who actually work in the mountains, especially on Everest. Through examining Nepal, we can see how colonial attitudes and methodologies regarding conservation management have emerged as new pathways

¹⁸ Berkes, Colding, and Folke, “Rediscovery of Traditional Ecological Knowledge as Adaptive Management.”

¹⁹ Ahlborg and Nightingale, “Mismatch Between Scales of Knowledge in Nepalese Forestry.”

²⁰ To be discussed in more depth later on.

²¹ Dhakal, “Overview of Tourism Development Prospects in Nepal.”

of power in the internal policies of nations in the Global South. These new forms of governance often come into direct conflict with local populations.

In 1957, the Private Forest Nationalization Act converted the ownership of all private forests to property of the Nepali Government. The goal of this act was to prevent private landowners from logging forests on their property,²² but it also meant that the state now owned much of the country's natural places. Rural populations were outraged by this legislation, as the management of this land that was once in the hands of people or villages was now transferred to the national government, which, for the most part, had little experience with and knowledge of the area.²³ In 1973, the Nepali government passed the National Park and Wildlife Conservation Act, which made it possible for the administration to grant official National Park status to many natural areas it now owned. As a result, management of this land in the newly established National Parks was legally put into the hands of the national government. Applying Tania Murray Li's concept of technical rendering,²⁴ it is obvious that by ascribing technical blame to populations for the degradation of their local environment and thus ignoring the colonial underpinnings that generated the economic issues which restricted these populations, the technical solution of moving people off their land is seen as the only answer.

A new form of environmental colonialism through the process of governance can be seen in Nepal's Sagarmatha National Park, the home of Mount Everest. Sagarmatha NP was established in 1976 in the Khumbu Valley of Nepal in response to concerns regarding the conservation of the Everest region. This has led to rapid tourism growth and globalization, which

²² Stevens, "National Parks and ICCAs in the High Himalayan Region of Nepal."

²³ Sivinski, "Conservation For Whom?: The Struggle for Indigenous Rights in Sagarmatha National Park."

²⁴ Murray, *The Will to Improve*.

strengthens the relationships between social-ecological change in this area and national, regional, and global drivers of change. These shifting relationships have resulted in intensified resource use, loss of resource management options, and weakened traditional, institutional, and social controls and feedback loops. The Nepalese government's first Park Management Plan bears much resemblance to international imperial and colonial policies that seem to have been internalized as part of Nepal's national administration. The plan allowed local people to continue to live in the park, but it also strengthened state control over local resources at the expense of traditional management systems. The Himalayan National Park Regulations, established in 1979, prohibited many customary natural resource uses in national parks. An example of this is the bans that have been placed on customary subsistence and on long-standing, small-scale market hunting, fishing, rotational forest farming, collection of non-timber forest resources, wild foods, and medicines, and the burning of forest floors and grasslands to improve grazing. Through these bans, the Nepalese government is ignoring the importance of subsistence activities to indigenous peoples' cultures and livelihoods, as well as their roles in maintaining cultural landscapes and ecosystems.²⁵

The third form of environmental colonialism, which is most commonly seen today, has been made possible through globalization and the footprints of colonist processes. Modern forms of technology and trade have constructed a reality where small actions in one area can adversely impact regions on the other side of the world. Through this, environmental colonialism has become its own entity that no longer relies on institutions of direct (and often physical) subjugation. The disparity between many countries' carbon emission rates and level of vulnerability to the negative effects of climate change is one example of how environmental

²⁵ Campbell, "Nature's Discontents in Nepal."

colonialism has shifted in practice and scope. One attempt to measure this disparity, the Notre Dame Global Adaptation Initiative, uses data-driven methods to identify areas of the world most vulnerable to the effects of climate change with the goal of preventing large-scale disasters. They calculated the vulnerability of Nepal to be 0.521 (the closer to 1, the more at risk a country is), and their readiness to be 0.356 (the closer to 1, the more prepared a country is). In comparison, the vulnerability of the United States was found to be 0.296, and its readiness was 0.683.²⁶ These measurements of vulnerability mostly have a negative association with global rates of greenhouse gas emissions. In 2020, researchers calculated countries' greenhouse gas emissions per capita. They found that the United States emits an estimated 17.1 tonnes of CO₂ per person, but on the other hand, Nepal's estimated greenhouse gas emissions per capita were found to be 0.47²⁷

*“Tourism, the hedonistic face of neocolonialism.”*²⁸ As a mostly indirect but deeply interrelated effect of imperialism, the Global South travel industry acts as another manifestation of neocolonialism, again made possible through the colonial roots of globalization. Here, the indirect effects of imperial efforts are now coming from another source- rather than the administrative bodies, it is the colonial country's citizens themselves that perpetuate legacies of marginalization. Populations from the Global North that benefit from persistent economic disparities in the Global South are fascinated by the exoticism of these foreign places. Compelled by the cultural and environmental ‘other’, many foreign tourists travel to the Global South and act in irresponsible and uneducated ways. Further, this tourism promotes the development of international travel agencies, which directs money and power away from local populations and

²⁶ Dame, “Rankings // Notre Dame Global Adaptation Initiative // University of Notre Dame.”

²⁷ Olivier, “TRENDS IN GLOBAL CO₂ AND TOTAL GREENHOUSE GAS EMISSIONS.”

²⁸ “Tourism in the Caribbean.”

concentrates it in the hands of foreign companies.²⁹ Even in post-colonial areas that gained their independence decades ago, the marketing of travel destinations and production of touristic landscapes both echo and reproduce colonial notions of adventure, exoticism, and cheap luxuries.³⁰ Although the foreign travel industry is not as directly related to environmental colonialism, in some parts of the world, the issue of tourists degrading local environments has become a significant point of contention.

In Nepal, the issue of garbage in the Everest Base Camp on the mountain itself has been a part of global discourse and media headlines for decades.³¹ Expedition agencies typically use hundreds of kilograms of gear and supplies throughout the course of the climbing season, but in the first few decades of Everest mountaineering, climbing groups employed the “out of sight, out of mind” mentality regarding the large amounts of trash they generated³². Abandoning no longer necessary equipment, such as empty oxygen tanks and broken tents, food packaging, and various other items on the mountain during and after the expedition was a common practice that was seen as acceptable and justifiable.³³ However, the accumulation of garbage on Everest due to extreme weather conditions that make trash hard to remove, and the recent exponential influx of tourists to the Khumbu Valley (Everest) region, has put significant pressure on the fragile ecosystem, generating concerns about the long-term sustainability of Everest tourism. In 1993, Barry Bishop, an American mountaineer, claimed that South Col on Everest was “the world’s highest junkyard.”³⁴ Nepalese government institutions additionally don’t enforce regulations on

²⁹ Williams, “Tourism as a Neo-Colonial Phenomenon.”

³⁰ Linehan, Clark, and Xie, *COLONIALISM, TOURISM AND PLACE Global Transformations in Tourist Destinations*.

³¹ “Solid Waste Pollution versus Sustainable Development in High Mountain Environment: A Case Study of Sagarmatha National Park of Khumbu Region, Nepal | HimalDoc.”

³² Nepal and Mu, “Mountaineering, Commodification and Risk Perceptions in Nepal’s Mt. Everest Region.”

³³ Bishop and Naumann, “Mount Everest.”

³⁴ Bishop and Naumann.

trekking agencies. This allows foreign climbers and entrepreneurs to set up their own companies that exclude the locals who already have intimate relations with and expert knowledge of Everest. Because of this lack of regulations, mountaineering tour companies in the Everest area now compete with each other to offer the lowest expedition prices. Trekking agencies with long histories of safe and successful summits now have to decrease their price to contend with newer companies whose staff are more likely to be untrained and inexperienced. Not only does this create a frustrating scenario for Khumbu residents who directly engage in the mountaineering industry, but it also creates more dangerous conditions for summiting Everest.

So what can be done about the embedded environmental legacies of colonialism? The only plausible solution to ecological management and conservation issues in the Global South seems to be bottom-up, focusing on empowering Indigenous and localized community members. One of the most compelling initiatives of rights-based approaches to environmental development in recent years has been the establishment of formal and informal Indigenous Peoples' and Community Conserved Territories and Areas, or ICCAS (Alcorn and Royo 2007; Campese 2009; Greiber et al. 2009; Stevens 2009, 2010; Shrumm and Campese 2010). ICCAs, ecosystems that are voluntarily conserved by Indigenous and other communities through local or customary laws, have enormous potential in contributing to national and global conservation systems.³⁵ These protected areas embody diverse political conditions, as they are found throughout the world in varying social and bureaucratic contexts. Regions that were once colonial expressions of control over Indigenous and local communities' lands, waters, and lives have since been "given back" to the original owners of the land. When national/international powers failed to protect and

³⁵ Berkes, "Community Conserved Areas."

conserve these environments from the great harm that has already been done, some stakeholders have finally begun to realize the importance of Indigenous people in managing the land.

Many ICCAs have failed to be officially recognized by formal governmental institutions as they require political and social relationships based on respect for cultural differences, appreciation of indigenous knowledge, recognition of their stewardship responsibilities, and affirmation of their human and Indigenous rights. However, the Nepalese government has done some good in supporting Indigenous rights- in 2007 The Legislative Parliament of Nepal approved the ratification of the Convention on Indigenous and Tribal Peoples adopted by the International Labor Organization in 1989, becoming the first country in South Asia to ratify this Convention and the only second country in all of Asia to do so- “The Convention supports the principle of self-management and guarantees the right of indigenous people to consultation and participation in issues relating to their own development. It guarantees their right to equal treatment and access to state services and also includes specific provisions for protecting and promoting indigenous and tribal peoples’ cultures and communities. Among other aspects, it protects the right to practice traditional economies, to traditional land and resources, and to use indigenous languages in education.”³⁶ Another positive is the implementation of the Local Adaptation Plan of Action (LAPA), a six-step framework that has been adopted by the Nepalese government to integrate climate change discourse into governance and the planning process.³⁷

Through tracing the evolution of environmental colonialism within the context of South Asia and the Mount Everest region of Nepal, I found that the problematization of conservation

³⁶ *Understanding the Indigenous and Tribal Peoples Convention, 1989 (No. 169).*

³⁷ “Khumbu Local Adaptation Plan for Action (LAPA).”

management by local populations deemed unfit to be in charge, and therefore necessitation of international interference and development, is an expression of neocolonialism. I identified the three temporally and spatially distinct yet interrelated configurations of environmental colonialism to have manifested through militarization, governance, and indirect anthropogenic activities. As globalization drastically alters the ways that human populations interact with each other and the environment, the legacies of imperialism are not forgotten in the environmental issues that threaten contemporary societies. Through tracing the evolution of green imperialism, I found the militarization of conquest and natural resource extraction, governance of local populations by foreign administrative bodies, global climate change, and tourism in the Global South to be intrinsically linked forms of environmental colonialism.

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